

USUCGER 2025 Annual Meeting Minutes

Monday, March 3, 2025

4:00 p.m. – 5:00 p.m. Eastern Time

Room L011, Kentucky International Convention Center, Louisville, KY, and via Zoom

Jack Montgomery (USUCGER President) presided over the 2025 USUCGER Annual Meeting. The meeting minutes were prepared by Jim Kaklamanos (USUCGER Secretary) with contributions from Ryan Shamet.

Attendees (in-person and online):

USUCGER Board Members:

- Jack Montgomery, President
- Jim Kaklamanos, Secretary
- Joseph Coe, Treasurer
- Estéfan Garcia, Membership Coordinator
- Matt Evans
- Diane Moug
- Marika Santagata
- Ryan Shamet
- Kaleigh Yost

Attendees:

- Kristin Sample-Lord (USUCGER Webmaster)
- Khalid Alshibli
- Ahmet Aydilek
- Paola Bandini
- Patrick Bassal
- Ryan Beemer
- Gretchen Bohnhoff
- Danilo Botero Lopez
- Jonathan Bray
- Sandeep Chitta
- Sheng Dai
- Amy Diekmann
- Theresa Engler
- Jongwan Eun
- Omid Ghasemi Fare
- Matthew Glisson
- Mike Gomez
- Peggy Hagerty Duffy
- Reihaneh Hosseini
- Amalesh Jana
- Ed Kavazanjian
- Kyle Kershaw
- Ben Leshchinsky
- Julia Loshelder

- Tyler Oathes
- Fernando Patino
- Ryan Rasanen
- Cassie Rutherford
- Mohammadhossein Sadeghiamirshahidi
- Martha Santos
- Joseph Scalia
- Anthony Tessari
- Calvin Tohm
- Xiong Zhang
- Jorge Zornberg

Minutes:

1. Introductions and welcome of new board members
 - a. The meeting was called to order at 4:04 p.m. Eastern Time.
 - b. Three new board members introduced themselves to the membership:
 - i. Marika Santagata (Purdue University)
 - ii. Ryan Shamet (University of North Florida)
 - iii. Kaleigh Yost (Penn State University)
2. Treasurer's report (Joseph Coe, Treasurer)
 - a. USUCGER has two accounts: a bank account and a PayPal account. Membership dues are deposited into the PayPal account, and funds are occasionally transferred to the bank account.
 - b. As of February 28, 2025, there are a total of \$46,918.29 in total assets, with \$40,291.68 in the bank account and \$6,626.61 in the PayPal account. USUCGER is in a healthy position financially.
 - c. All revenues come from membership dues, at \$75 per member for three years (i.e., equivalent to \$25 per person per year).
 - d. We currently have \$25,000 earmarked for the USUCGER Early Career Workshop, and at least \$5,000 for the USUCGER Special Projects program.
 - e. Kristin Sample-Lord (Webmaster) noted that we expect 375 to 400 total members to pay membership dues (based on the previous cycle); 73 members have paid so far.
 - f. Estéfan Garcia (Membership Coordinator) will send a reminder email on dues in two months.
3. Webmaster's report
 - a. Website and listserv updates (Kristin Sample-Lord, Webmaster)
 - i. Kristin noted that members can email the USUCGER webmaster to post faculty positions on its webpage, and listings will stay up for a year after the initial posting. Once the position has been filled, please email the webmaster to have the listing removed.
 - ii. If you send an email to all@usucger.org, it should go straight out to members.
 - iii. Email the USUCGER Webmaster at webmaster@usucger.org with any questions.
 - b. Guidelines for use of email list (Jack Montgomery, President)

- i. Jack mentioned that it was noted at last year's Annual Meeting that there was no policy on acceptable use, so the Board is bringing that forth this year.
 - ii. There are no concerns about acceptable use at this time, but the Board wanted a policy in place before an issue arose. We did not want to wait until spam started filling the listserv. The key is keeping the listserv non-commercial, i.e. not a forum for advertising commercial products.
 - iii. The draft acceptable use policy is included in **Appendix A** of this document; it includes examples of appropriate and inappropriate uses of our email list.
 - iv. The Board is seeking input from USUCGER members; please provide comments on the draft document at <https://aub.ie/dRGLfa> and/or by emailing the USUCGER Board at uboard@usucger.org.
 - v. We are hoping to finalize the policy this summer, after which it will be posted on the USUCGER website.
- 4. USUCGER Membership and Dues (Estéfan Garcia, Membership Coordinator)
 - a. Membership Coordinator position
 - i. The Membership Coordinator position is a new board-level position responsible for managing all tasks related to memberships and dues payments.
 - ii. Previously, these duties were subdivided between the Webmaster, Treasurer, and President. The new structure provides a single consolidated point of contact; Estéfan Garcia is our inaugural Membership Coordinator.
 - b. 2025 - 2027 dues cycle
 - i. Dues remain at \$75 per member for the three-year cycle (i.e., \$25 per person per year) and are not prorated. This fee is per person and not per university or organization.
 - ii. You can find all the details and pay your dues here: <https://usucger.org/usucger-membership-overview/>.
 - iii. For institutions with more than one member, Cassie Rutherford asked if it made any difference to for an institution to pay their dues for all members at once (i.e. in one transaction), or individually in separate transactions. Jack and Kristin noted that it does not make a difference on USUCGER's end, so institutions should pay their duties in whichever manner is most convenient (i.e., all together or separately).
 - c. USUCGER membership directory
 - i. The USUCGER Board is working on a searchable membership directory to be available on our website, with the goal of rolling it out later this year.
 - ii. The goal of the membership directory is to help connect members to other members. Members will be able to search for those with similar interests to identify potential collaborators (for example, identifying all individuals in USUCGER working on deep foundations research in the U.S.)
 - iii. Cassie Rutherford asked about the potential for making a speaker database; Jack noted that perhaps we could add a checkbox for interest in speaking opportunities.

- iv. Jack stated that every three years (e.g., aligned with the dues cycle), you will be asked to update your membership entry in the directory.
 - v. Angel Palomino asked about what to do with members of USUCGER who are not paying their dues. Jack noted that outreach to non-paying members is going to be something Estéfan will be working on as part of his new role.
- 5. USUCGER Special Projects (Joseph Coe, Treasurer)
 - a. A new call has been posted for the USUCGER Special Projects grant program, with proposals due via email to Joe (joseph.coe@sjsu.edu) on Friday, April 4, 2025.
 - b. There are two categories of projects:
 - i. Category 1 – General projects that support any aspect of the USUCGER mission to further geotechnical engineering education and research
 - ii. Category 2 – Research Advocacy projects that support the advocacy mission of USUCGER in geotechnical research
 - c. Category 1 projects can be awarded up to \$5,000, but Category 2 (Research advocacy) projects could be awarded a larger figure with justifications. The Board came up with the idea a year ago for Category 2 projects, but this area is even more pressing now given the uncertainty with federal funding.
 - d. If members have any questions, please send them to Joe or Jack. Membership dues must be current in order to apply for a USUCGER special project.
- 6. USUCGER Early Career Workshop (Jack Montgomery, President)
 - a. Susan Burns at Georgia Tech is leading the effort for the upcoming USUCGER Early Career workshop. This is the third USUCGER Early Career Workshop that has been offered, following two previous successful workshops in 2012 in Boston and 2018 in Cleveland.
 - b. The workshop is a two-day event focused on issues that are impactful for the initiation of an academic career in today's rapidly changing research and teaching environment. Funding for the workshop will come from both USUCGER and NSF; we are budgeting for approximately 35 early-career faculty, along with speakers from industry and academia.
 - c. The original plan was to hold the workshop in May 2025, but given the delays in funding approvals from NSF, the workshop will most likely occur in Fall 2025.
 - d. Amy Diekmann asked about the application process. Jack responded that the application is not currently live; more details will be made available to the membership when the dates are finalized. The application, when it is ready, will be advertised across multiple channels.
- 7. USUCGER Awards Ceremony
 - a. Jack presented the USUCGER 2025 Early Career Researcher Award to Sheng Dai (Georgia Tech) and the USUCGER 2025 Distinguished Service Award to Ed Kavazanjian (Arizona State University). Jack presented each recipient an award certificate, delivered a statement about each recipient, and then offered the awardee the opportunity to deliver remarks.
 - b. USUCGER 2025 Early Career Researcher Award: Sheng Dai (Georgia Tech)
 - i. *Award statement:* Dr. Sheng Dai is awarded the 2025 USUCGER Early Career Researcher Award for his significant and innovative contributions

to energy geotechnics, waste-to-energy conversion, and nature-inspired geotechnics. His multi-disciplinary work includes developing unique devices for testing deep-sea sediments, understanding the flow of biomass materials for biofuel production, and investigating bio-inspired rock drilling techniques. Dr. Dai's research has resulted in numerous publications in high-impact journals and has been funded by federal and state agencies, national labs, and industry. He is also recognized for his outstanding teaching, mentorship, and significant service to the geo-community.

- ii. *Remarks:* Sheng offered gratitude for receiving this award, and acknowledged his colleagues and collaborators.
- c. USUCGER 2025 Distinguished Service Award: Ed Kavazanjian (Arizona State University)
 - i. *Award Statement:* Professor Edward Kavazanjian, Jr. is awarded the 2025 USUCGER Distinguished Service Award for his extensive contributions to USUCGER and his leadership within the larger geotechnical engineering community. Professor Kavazanjian has been an active supporter of USUCGER since 2004, serving as a board member from 2012 - 2020 and as president from 2015 - 2018. Professor Kavazanjian played a key role in enhancing multiple USUCGER programs, including creating the Special Projects program and re-instituting several USUCGER Awards. He has also served in many other leadership roles across a range of organizations, including serving as President of the ASCE Geo-Institute and Chair of the National Research Council Standing Committee on Geotechnical and Geological Engineering. His lifelong record of service to the geotechnical profession makes him a worthy recipient of the award.
 - ii. *Remarks:* Ed provided his perspective of the history of USUCGER and how it began as a research advocacy group in the wake of potential loss of funding for the geotechnical engineering program from NSF in the mid-1980s. The organization evolved from focusing mainly on research, to focusing on both research and education. He then discussed the current state of affairs with regards to uncertainty with federal funding, and the importance of the work that we do as engineering researchers. Ed expressed optimism that those making federal funding decisions will understand the value of what we do, and that the time to start building coalitions for research advocacy is now. He concluded with expressing his gratitude for this recognition.
- d. Recognition of USUCGER Student Travel Grant recipients
 - i. USUCGER supported three students from member universities to attend Geotechnical Frontiers 2025 in Louisville, and all of them attended the Annual Meeting to be recognized:
 - 1. Martha Maria Santos (University of Central Florida)
 - 2. Calvin Tohm (South Dakota School of Mines)
 - 3. Danilo Botero Lopez (University of Maine)

- ii. Last year, the travel grant was expanded to include conferences other than Geo-Congress; Kike Garzon-Sabogal (Purdue University) attended International Symposium on Geomechanics in Fall 2024 with the help of this grant.
 - iii. The USUCGER Board will be accepting applications for summer conferences (i.e., travel from May 1 to August 31 of this year), and an email will be sent to the membership in the very near future. Applications will be due on Tuesday, April 1, 2025. The Student Travel Grant application announcement is available at: https://drive.google.com/open?id=1te3RyVL8ug05Xs8ve0Vo1mV75RjCS21B&usp=drive_fs
- 8. Planning for the Future of USUCGER (Jack Montgomery, President)
 - a. Survey results
 - i. Jack noted that in 2023, when he became President, he was interested in having USUCGER think about its roots in research advocacy. The uncertainty in the state of federal research funding in the past couple months has turbocharged this reflection.
 - ii. He presented the results of a survey sent to all USUCGER members on the effects of federal research funding uncertainty. As of the meeting, 24 individuals have responded, but hopefully more will do so after this meeting (the survey link is available at https://auburn.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_dp1omEsuOisjtn8).
 - iii. The vast majority of respondents were extremely concerned about federal research funding (Question 1), there was a mixed result about impacts to hiring (but many are having problems given the uncertainty) (Question 2); and a large number of individuals are very pessimistic about the future of federal funding for geotechnical and/or geoenvironmental research (Question 3).
 - iv. Examples of impacts include:
 - 1. The major impact seems to be uncertainty
 - 2. Some current grants and renewals are in limbo
 - 3. Access to federal resources (collaborators, facilities) is limited
 - 4. Several respondents indicated that the uncertainty is impacting their ability to make offers to new students
 - b. Advocacy activities mentioned from survey results
 - i. Working with other organizations (e.g., ASCE) on lobbying and statements (Jack noted that Brad Keelor at ASCE offered to connect USUCGER with ASCE Government Relations).
 - ii. Convey impacts to industry and legislators (although we should be wary about making specific statements given the current state of uncertainty)
 - iii. Share advocacy resources (e.g., template letters)
 - iv. Start a funding bank to share information on opportunities
 - c. Strategic planning discussion
 - i. Jack noted that USUCGER's strategic plan has not been updated in a long time. Now would be a good time to set a vision for where we should see

ourselves going as an organization. He opened the floor to comments from attendees.

- ii. Peggy Hagerty Duffy spoke about the importance of promoting the work we do more broadly to the non-technical community, focusing on safety. We need to speak the language of the general public and emphasize the importance of safe infrastructure.
- iii. Susan Burns noted that she shares with her direct community on Facebook the importance of our work, starting the discussion in layman's terms.
- iv. Diane Moug emphasized the importance of focusing on early-career faculty, and how we can help them at this time. It was suggested that perhaps we could share resources such as laboratory access or software.
- v. Cassie Rutherford addressed the impact that federal research funding cuts could have on the tenure and promotion process. Alternatives to grant funding (such as additional journal publications) could be weighed more heavily.
- vi. Ryan Beemer mentioned that a lot of focus in the media has been on cuts to indirect costs, but there could also be impacts to summer salary, reverting to how grants were structured before the 1980s. Perhaps we should consider an advocacy group for summer salary.
- vii. Marika Santagata asked what we can do collectively as an organization, as well as individually, to advocate for our field. Perhaps we could update the website and include videos targeted in explaining what exactly geotechnical/geoenvironmental engineers do and their importance.
- viii. Matt Evans asked if USUCGER has a LinkedIn account. We do not currently have one, but perhaps it may be worth considering.
- ix. Jack Montgomery mentioned that one theme that came out of the survey results was that perhaps we could be more outward-facing as an organization rather than inward-facing. Much of our website is internal for our members. We could update it somehow to emphasize why geotechnical engineering work matters to the general public.
- x. Ed Kavazanjian noted that public outreach and education would make for a good special project.
- xi. Ryan Beemer was interviewed by a local journalist from a New Bedford, Mass., newspaper about offshore wind. The journalist was ecstatic about talking to him and writing up the article. Perhaps we could reach out to local newspapers proactively, as this could help generate interest in the work we do.
- xii. Jack summarized the feedback during this meeting: members are interested in USUCGER working on public-facing advocacy, getting the public to know the work what we do as geotechnical/geoenvironmental engineers.
- xiii. Jack said that members are welcome to send along other ideas to the Board as well.

9. Other business

- a. ASCE G-I Education Committee (Cassie Rutherford): Cassie encouraged USUCGER members to consider joining the ASCE G-I Education Committee

(formerly the ASCE G-I Continuing Education Committee). She talked about the goals of the newly structured committee and that they are planning outreach to other committees. The new focus of the committee will also include K-12, undergraduate and graduate education. Cassie sent a follow-up email directly after the meeting mentioning that the committee will not be meeting in person at the GeoFrontiers conference. If you are interested in joining the committee, please reach out to the chair Ivan Guzman: IGuzman@CityTech.Cuny.Edu. They are planning a virtual committee meeting in the next few weeks.

- b. Geotechnical Engineering Education Survey from ISSMGE TC306 (Technical Committee on Geoengineering Education) (Jorge Zornberg): Jorge encouraged one faculty member from each institution to complete a geotechnical engineering education survey at a link provided in an email to USUCGER (https://utexas.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_5nWG9EflTbXrazs). The survey focuses on the structure of the geotechnical courses within your institution's undergraduate and/or graduate programs as well as on the number of lectures dedicated to teaching geosynthetics within your curriculum. The survey will take about 10 minutes to complete and is to be conducted by only one faculty member in your institution (tentatively the USUCGER representative or a faculty member familiar with geosynthetics within your group).
10. Updates from other organizations
 - a. Updates from other GeoCoalition organizations will be included in the minutes. They are available in **Appendix B** of this document.
 - b. Appendix B contains updates from the following organizations:
 - i. ASCE G-I Board of Governors
 - ii. Deep Foundations Institute (DFI)
 - iii. Geoprofessional Business Association (GBA)
 - c. Students are encouraged to explore scholarship opportunities and travel grants from these organizations. Some links are below:
 - i. <https://www.adsc-iafd.com/research-scholarships/scholarships/>
 - ii. <https://dfi.org/scholarships/>
 - iii. <https://www.ussdams.org/scholarships/>
 - iv. <https://www.ascefoundation.org/briaud-students-fund>
 11. Discussion and questions from members
 - a. Cassie Rutherford encouraged students to enter next year's Geo-Challenge Competitions.
 - b. Ed Kavazanjian announced the 2025 International Conference on Bio-mediated and Bio-inspired Geotechnics (ICBBG) to be held at Arizona State University from 18-20 May 2025.
 12. USUCGER Board meeting; election of new USUCGER President
 - a. The general meeting was adjourned at 4:57 p.m. Eastern Time. Slides from the general meeting are available in **Appendix C** of this document.
 - b. Members of the USUCGER Board remained after the general meeting was adjourned for an important action: to elect a new President for years 2025 to 2027.
 - c. Ryan Shamet nominated Diane Moug to become the next USUCGER President. This nomination was seconded by Joe Coe.

- d. Diane was unanimously elected by the Board to become USUCGER President effective at our next board meeting. The board congratulated Diane on her election, and thanked Jack for his service as President for the past two years!
- e. The Board adjourned at 4:59 p.m. Eastern Time.

Appendix A

Draft Acceptable Use Policy for USUCGER Mailing List

Members are encouraged to provide comments on the draft document at <https://aub.ie/dRGLfa> and/or by emailing the USUCGER Board at uboard@usucger.org.

Draft Acceptable Use Policy for USUCGER Mailing List for Comments

- USUCGER maintains a mailing list for the benefit of its members and to maintain connectivity between geotechnical and geoenvironmental faculty.
- The USUCGER webmaster is responsible for maintaining the mailing list, including adding and removing users and approving emails sent from outside entities.
- USUCGER members and affiliates are added to the mailing list by default when joining for the first time. They can unsubscribe at any time by contacting the USUCGER webmaster.
- USUCGER reserves the right to unsubscribe members with delinquent dues and remove outdated email accounts at any time. The USUCGER webmaster will attempt to notify individuals prior to removing them from the list.
- All use of the USUCGER mailing list must comply with all federal, state and other applicable laws; all generally applicable Oregon State Board of Higher Education and Oregon State University rules and policies (where our mailing list is hosted); and all applicable contracts and licenses. Users are responsible for ascertaining, understanding, and complying with the laws, rules, policies, contracts, and licenses applicable to their particular uses of the mailing list.
- Messages sent to the USUCGER list should be courteous, appropriate, and of general interest to USUCGER members. Messages of limited interest to the general membership, such as individual project or paper announcements or personal and holiday greetings are not appropriate for the USUCGER mailing list.
- USUCGER reserves the right to reject any message that is considered offensive or inappropriate.
- Examples of appropriate use of the USUCGER mailing list include, but are not limited to:
 - Sharing information about upcoming noncommercial webinars, conferences, or workshops
 - Providing links to potential external funding opportunities
 - Advertising new post-doc or faculty positions
 - Sharing resources related to teaching, research, or advocacy
 - Sharing surveys related to geotechnical or geoenvironmental engineering research or education
 - Sharing retirement announcements or memorials for USUCGER members or other geotechnical or geoenvironmental faculty
 - Discussions related to the broader area of geotechnical and geoenvironmental engineering (e.g., What is cohesion really? How do we learn to stop worrying and love AI?)
- Examples of inappropriate use of the USUCGER mailing list include, but are not limited to:
 - Messages that promote products or services for commercial gain

- Messages that contain statements, language, images or other materials that are reasonably likely to be perceived as harassing, offensive, sexual in nature, or disparaging of others based on race, national origin, sex, sexual orientation, age, disability, religious or political beliefs.
- Messages that misrepresent, obscure, suppress, or replace the sender's identity. This includes the use of false or misleading subject headers and/or subject lines.
- Messages that solicit money for religious or political causes, or advocate religious or political opinions or candidates.
- Sending spam, junk mail, chain letters or other unsolicited bulk email, commercial or otherwise.
- Using the mailing list for any illegal purposes, including initiating or receiving communications that violate any laws and regulations. This includes malicious use, spreading of viruses, and hacking.
- USUCGER reserves the right to unsubscribe any members without further notice in case of what is considered offensive behaviour or repeated inappropriate use of the mailing list.
- Copyright of messages sent to the USUCGER mailing list is retained by the sender.
- Messages sent to the USUCGER mailing list may be archived.

Appendix B

Updates from GeoCoalition Organizations

This appendix contains updates provided by representatives of the American Society of Civil Engineers (ASCE) Geo-Institute Board of Governors, Deep Foundations Institute (DFI), and Geoprofessional Business Association (GBA).

G-I BOG Updates from Helen Robinson

- Call for nomination for Board of Governors- Due April 4th, can self-nominate (1 position open)
- Call for nominations for Board Level Committee members- Due April 4th, can self-nominate
- Call for nominations for ISSMGE VP for North America for next term (2026-2029). This rotates among US, Canada and Mexico (Walter Paniagua from Mexico is current VP). Due April 4th, can self-nominate
- BOG is seeking suggestions for members of the Nominations and Elections Committee (NEC). This is a temporary committee consisting of the VP, Treasurer, and 3 other G-I members. Send your suggestions to any Governor or TCC Counselor
- New members needed for the Education Committee (used to be Continuing Education Committee). Looking to refresh the committee and its objectives to focus on all types of education. All are welcome, academia needed in particular
- 25th Anniversary of Geo-Strata!! Congratulations to Jim Withiam, Editor in Chief, and Kristie Kehoe, Content Editor, and all our volunteer editors
- Live Business meeting on March 25th- join and ask questions live
- Outreach and Engagement Council now houses Younger Member Committee, Geo-Challenge Committee, Student Leadership Committee
- Younger member committee- looking for members. Come see the new Younger Members Technical Session on Tuesday morning 10:30 am- 12 pm. Winner of the competition will present in the Plenary session on Wednesday morning.
- In the BOG meeting on Saturday, we took the first steps in creating a designated 2-year Younger Member board position. We are working on updating the by-laws to add a 9th Governor for this purpose.
- Geo-Coalition Workforce Development Survey- please fill it out no matter your role in the industry (consultant, contractor, marketing, engineer, geologist, academic, etc). This will help us understand hiring/recruiting needs and when you selected a career in the geo-profession. The Geo-Coalition is a partnership among: ASCE G-I, ADSC, AEG, PDCA, DFI, USUCGER, GBA.



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TECHNICAL ACTIVITIES UPDATE – MARCH 2025

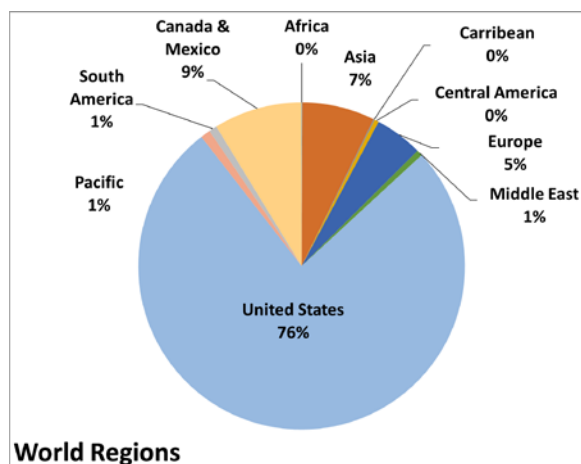
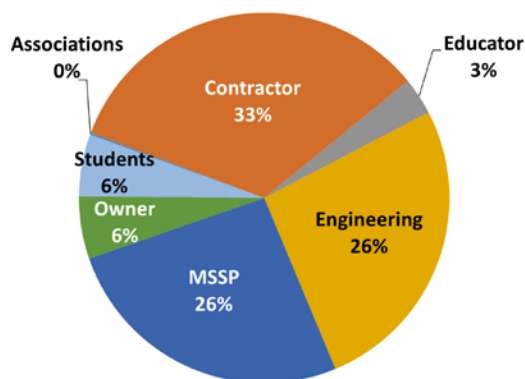
DFI President: James Johnson, Condon-Johnson & Associates, jjohnson@condon-johnson.com

DFI Executive Director: Theresa Engler, tengler@dfi.org

DFI Director of Technical Activities: Matthew R. Glisson, P.E., mglisson@dfi.org

DFI INFO: DFI website at www.dfi.org, nearly 4,000 members in about 50 countries.

Organization Types



DFI STRATEGIC INITIATIVES

- Industry Awareness and Advancement: Highlight industry career opportunities to attract talent to our members.
- Corporate Membership Growth: Increase DFI's network of professionals to further build our thriving community.
- Themed Conference Vision and Planning: Create impactful, engaging and forward-thinking events on timely topics.

DFI COMMUNITIES ACTIVITIES

- Over 580 active members involved in: 29 DFI Technical Committees, 2 working groups (risk and working platforms) with multiple North American associations, 6 EFFC-DFI task groups (**New in 2025: EFFC/DFI NDT Guide Task Group**), Geo-Coalition and U.S. Levee Safety Coalition.
- Host Geo-Industry Technology Users Groups: Cone Penetration Testing (CPT), Measurement While Drilling (MWD), and Geophysics.
- Midyear Committee Week (April 28 to May 2): All DFI committees meet online; meetings are open to everyone in the industry. See [schedule](#) and register to attend meetings of committees to which you don't currently belong.
- 7 committees are organizing webinar series for a total of 17 webinars in 2025. Visit [here](#) for more information! (90 minutes for presentation and questions; Free to all with no PDH certificate or \$70 with a PDH certificate).
- Visit [Communities](#) webpage and check out [Deep Foundations Magazine](#) for more updates.

DFI TRAVELING LECTURER

- The 2024-2025 lecturer is Matthew E. Meyer, P.E., BC.GE. See remaining lecture dates [here](#).
- Series runs September 1 to August 31 of the following year with nominations accepted continuously.
- Next lecturer will be announced in May or June. Visit [Traveling Lecturer](#) webpage to learn more.

DFI COMMITTEE PROJECT FUND

- About \$1.6 million awarded for research and other committee projects since 2012.
- [Committee Project Fund](#) webpage summarizes current and completed projects and provides links to publications.
- 2025 funds awarded to five projects submitted by Driven Pile, Ground Improvement, Helical Piles & Tiebacks, Subsurface Characterization for Deep Foundations, and Sustainability Committees.
- Proposals invited for DFI committees' consideration by September 1; DFI committees submit on December 1.

DFI PUBLICATIONS

- **Recent publications-free downloads:** [Data Management Guide Specification for Basic Grouting Projects](#), [EFFC/DFI Carbon Reduction Guide](#), [EFFC/DFI Circular Economy Guide](#), and [Spanish translation of Helical Pile Design Guide](#).
- **Upcoming Publications:** Consensus publication on GBRs; guidance publication on foundations for electric power transmission structures; EFFC/DFI guides on water, climate adaptation and resilience, and gender equality and reduced inequalities; update to micropile guide specification; and more.
- [Deep Foundations Magazine](#): published six times per year, digital edition free to all online, DFI members receive print copies on request.
- [DFI Journal](#): published twice a year. Special issue on revisiting the classics by Bengt Fellenius in 2025. Submit your article at www.editorialmanager.com/dfi.
- [DFI Publications Store](#): offers a wide variety of technical resources, many free for download. Recent conference proceedings include presentation recordings and the ability to earn PDHs.
- [DFI Podcasts: Broadcasting Common Ground](#) The series *Interviews with the Industry* continues in 2025. Past series available for viewing/listening: *Morgan's Mentors*, *Interview with a Trailblazer*, *Deep Dive*, *Game Day (live at DFI Annual Conference)*, *Rumble* and *Interview with a Survivor*.

UPCOMING EVENTS

This year is DFI's 50th Anniversary – Celebrate with us in Nashville this October!

March 6, 2025	Impact Webinar	Online Webinar
March 27, 2025	New York City Ports and Marine Engineering Seminar	New York, NY
April 11, 2025	What's Shaking Webinar	Online Webinar
April 10, 2025	IT\$ Money Webinar	Online Webinar
April 22, 2025	EFFC/DFI Carbon Reduction and Circular Economy Webinar	Online Webinar
April 24, 2025	Deeper into Data Webinar	Online Webinar
April 28 – May 2, 2025	Midyear Committee Week	Virtual Meetings
May 7-8, 2025	Helical Piles-Tiebacks-Anchors Tradeshow and Educational Seminar	Durham, CT
May 21-23, 2025	DFI/EFFC International Conference on Deep Foundations and Ground Improvement: Geotechnics Reimagined	Bruges, Belgium
May 29, 2025	Sustainability Webinar	Online Webinar
June 18-20, 2025	SuperPile 2025	Cleveland, OH
July 24, 2025	International Grouting Webinar	Online Webinar
August 5-7, 2025	S3: Slopes, Support and Stabilization (DFI49)	Madison, WI
September 8-10, 2025	DFI India 14th Annual Conference on Deep Foundation Technologies for Infrastructure Development in India	Gujarat, India
October 20-23, 2025	DFI 50th Annual Conference on Deep Foundations (DFI50)	Nashville, TN
November 6-7, 2025	SMIG 7th International Symposium on Deep Foundations and Soil Improvement	Mexico City, Mexico
November 12-13, 2025	Shotcrete Short Course	Georgetown, KY

DFI STUDENT ACTIVITIES

- Free Student Memberships: apply [here](#) and submit your resume for viewing by DFI Corporate Members.
- Annual [Student](#) and [Young Professor](#) Paper Competitions. DFI51 Call for Abstracts opens this summer.
- DFI50 includes university and high school student programming.

DFI EDUCATIONAL TRUST – www.trust.dfi.org

- Awarded \$2.2 million in scholarships since inception to more than 550 students at almost 100 universities.
- Application period for 2025 Student Scholarships and Women in Deep Foundations professional development grants opens April 1, 2025.
- 21 Student Travel Grants to DFI Conferences available this year through the Paul DeBruyn Fund.

Follow us on social media





An Overview for our GeoCoaliton Friends

HISTORY

That history began when principals of ten consulting geotechnical engineering firms – then known as soil and foundation engineering firms – met in a Chicago airport hotel in December 1968 to resolve a common problem that threatened their companies: Professional-liability claims were at an all-time high and professional-liability insurers worldwide refused to cover them.

The ten formally launched what is now GBA as Associated Soil and Foundation Engineers, Inc. (ASFE) in May 1969 to identify the causes of professional liability claims and losses and to develop programs and materials to help geoprofessionals avoid such exposures in the future.

PURPOSE

To be the preferred source of business, educational resources, specifically risk management and business performance optimization for geoprofessional firms.

STRATEGY

Create value through unique member experiences that are not available elsewhere.

WE SERVE

GBA serves geoprofessional firms that provide geotechnical, geologic, environmental, construction-materials engineering and testing, and related civil-engineering and earth-science services.

VALUE PROPOSITION

We share diverse experiences to develop leaders and drive business success in a rapidly changing world.

BOARD OF DIRECTORS

Volunteer leaders from Member-Firms are elected to 3-year term with opportunity to extend their term as Executive Directors.

2024- 2025 Board of Directors

President:	Guy Marcozzi, P.E., LEED AP BD+C (Verdantas)
President-Elect:	Teresa L. Peterson, P.E., C.M.E., ENV SP (Gannett Fleming)
Secretary/Treasurer:	Dan Schaefer, P.E. (Froehling & Robertson)
Directors:	Kent Bannister, P.Eng. (TREK Geotechnical)
	Elizabeth Clarke (Structures Group)
	Victor R. Donald (Terracon)
	Carrie L. Foulk, P.E., P.G. (BSK Associates)
	Jeff Jaros (NTH Consultants)
	Stuart Thompson (CTL Thompson)

MEMBER BENEFITS

GBA is the only organization dedicated solely to helping geoprofessionals meet their unique business challenges. No other entity admires, respects, and supports geoprofessionals more than GBA and the individuals who comprise it, and everything that GBA does is designed to promote members' success.

The promise of GBA membership is that you will derive an outstanding ROI by applying the resources, knowledge, relationships, and education GBA has created to help its members and their clients confront risk and optimize performance.

- Employee recruiting and retention
- Employee professional development
- Client retention and referrals
- Business development
- Business partnerships
- Project management
- Risk management
- Business optimization

CURRENT INITIATIVES

- Transitioning to New Association Management System and Member Portal
- 2023-2024 Annual Report (attached)
- 2027 Strategic Plan
- 2025 Crystal Ball Workshop (seeking partners)
- Career Continuum Professional Development Coursework / Early Career Professionals
- Peer Group Initiatives
- First Word – A Monthly Video Update
- Podcasts

FOCUS AREAS

- Technology Advances including AI, Remote Sensing, Automation
- Risk Management
- Business Optimization
- Retention of Employees
- Pipeline of Future Geoprofessionals

MEMBER TYPES

- Member Firm
- Professional Colleague
- Practitioner
- Faculty
- Consultants

FORMAL PARTNERSHIPS

- Association of Environmental & Engineering Geologists (AEG)
- Association of Geotechnical & Geoenvironmental Specialists (AGS UK)
- California Geotechnical Engineering Association (CalGeo)
- Canadian Geotechnical Society (CGS)
- Geo-Institute of ASCE (G-I)

INFORMAL PARTNERSHIPS

- Deep Foundations Institute (DFI)
- International Association of Foundation Drilling (ADSC – IAFD)
- Pile Driving Contractors Association (PDCA)
- United States Universities Council on Geotechnical Education and Research (USUCGER)

COMMITTEES

- Business Practices Committee
- Construction Materials Engineering and Testing Business Committee
- Council of Fellows
- Emerging Issues and Trends Committee
- Environmental Business Committee
- Geotechnical Business Committee
- Inclusion Advancement Committee
- Legal Affairs Committee
- Multimedia Delivery Committee
- Peer Review Committee
- Resource Collaboration Committee

UPCOMING EVENTS

- Fall Leadership Summit – October 23-25, 2024
- Annual Conference – April 24-26, 2025
- Crystal Ball Workshop – June 24-26, 2025
- Annual Conference – April 23-25, 2026
- Annual Conference – April 15-17, 2027

For more information, please contact Joel G. Carson, CEO and Executive Director at JCarson@Geoprofessional.org or 402-517-1819.

Appendix C

PowerPoint Slides from USUCGER Annual Meeting

Take our survey!



Agenda

1. Introductions and welcome new board members
2. Treasurer's report (Joseph Coe)
3. Webmaster's report (Kristin Sample-Lord)
 - a. Website and listserv updates
 - b. Guidelines for use of email list
4. USUCGER Membership and Dues (Estéfan Garcia)
 - a. 2025 - 2027 dues cycle has started
 - b. Working on membership directory
5. USUCGER special projects (Joseph Coe)
 - a. New call has been posted with proposals due on April 4
6. Early Career Research Workshop - Update from Susan Burns (Georgia Tech)
7. USUCGER Awards Ceremony
 - a. Early Career Researcher: Sheng Dai
 - b. Distinguished Service: Ed Kavazanjian
 - c. Recognition of student travel grant winners
8. Planning for the Future of USUCGER
 - a. Survey results
 - b. Advocacy activities
 - c. Strategic planning initiative
9. Other business
 - a. USUCGER members should consider attending the Education Committee (formerly Continuing Education Committee) meeting on Tuesday 3-5pm L008
 - b. Geotech Education Survey from TC306 (Jorge Zornberg)

Introductions

► New board members

- Marika Santagata (Purdue)
- Ryan Shamet (UNF)
- Kaleigh Yost (Penn State)



USUCGER Annual Meeting

Treasurer's Report

- Bank Balance: \$40,291.⁶⁸ (as of 02/28/2025)
- PayPal Balance: \$6,626.⁶¹ (as of 02/28/2025)
- Total Assets: \$46,918.²⁹ (as of 02/28/2025)
- Membership Drive (2025-2027).
 - 73 members paid as of 02/28/2025
- Upcoming Expenditures
 - Special Projects
 - Early Career Workshop

USUCGER Annual Meeting

Webmaster's Report

- ▶ Website updates
- ▶ Draft acceptable use policy for email list
 - ▶ Outlines acceptable and unacceptable uses of our email list
 - ▶ No concerns at this time, but wanted a policy in place before there was an issue
 - ▶ Looking for comments from USUCGER members

<https://aub.ie/dRGLfa>



USUCGER Annual Meeting

Membership Coordinator's Report

- ▶ Membership Coordinator is a new board level position
 - ▶ Single position to manage all tasks related to memberships and dues payments
 - ▶ Estèfan Garcia is our inaugural Membership Coordinator
- ▶ 2025 – 2027 Dues Cycle has begun
 - ▶ Dues remain at \$75 per member for the three-year cycle and are not prorated
 - ▶ <https://usucger.org/usucger-membership-overview/>
- ▶ Currently working on building a searchable membership directory for the website (more info soon!)

USUCGER Annual Meeting

USUCGER Special Projects

- ▶ Accepting proposals for USUCGER Special Projects
 - ▶ Two categories:
 - ▶ 1 – General projects that support any aspect of the USUCGER mission to further geotechnical engineering education and research
 - ▶ 2 – Research Advocacy projects that support the advocacy mission of USUCGER in geotechnical research
 - ▶ Proposals should be submitted to USUCGER Board Treasurer (Joseph Coe) via email at joseph.coe@sjsu.edu. The deadline for proposal submission is 5 PM EDT, April 4, 2025

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Early Career Workshop (Susan Burns)

- ▶ Georgia Tech will be hosting the third USUCGER Early Career Workshop for geotechnical faculty
 - ▶ Two-day event focused on issues that are impactful for the initiation of an academic career in today's rapidly changing research and teaching environment
 - ▶ Originally targeting May 2025, but dates are likely to change as we await decisions from NSF

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USUCGER Awards – 2025 Early Career Researcher

► Sheng Dai (Georgia Tech)

- Recognized for his significant and innovative contributions to energy geotechnics, waste-to-energy conversion, and nature-inspired geotechnics
- Dr. Dai has shared his work through numerous publications in high-impact journals and has been funded by federal and state agencies, national labs, and industry.
- He is also recognized for his outstanding teaching, mentorship, and significant service to the geo-community



USUCGER Annual Meeting

USUCGER Awards – 2025 Distinguished Service Award

► Ed Kavazanjian (Arizona State)

- Recognized for his extensive contributions to USUCGER and his leadership within the larger geotechnical engineering community
- Professor Kavazanjian has been an active supporter an active supporter of USUCGER since 2004, serving as a board member from 2012 - 2020 and as president from 2015 - 2018
- He is also recognized for his lifelong record of service to the larger geotechnical profession



USUCGER Annual Meeting

Student Travel Grant Recipients

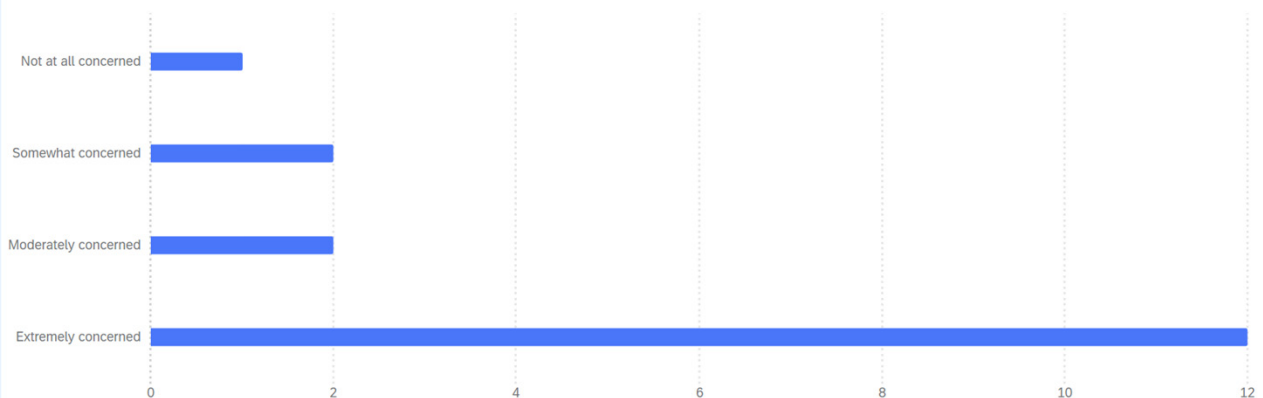
- ▶ USUCGER supported three students from member universities to attend Geotechnical Frontiers
 - ▶ Martha Maria Santos (UCF)
 - ▶ Calvin Tohm (SD School of Mines)
 - ▶ Danilo Botero Lopez (Maine)
- ▶ Last year the travel grant was expanded to include conferences other than Geo-Congress
 - ▶ Kike Garzon-Sabogal (Purdue) attended International Symposium on Geomechanics in the fall
 - ▶ Will be accepting applications for summer conferences

USUCGER Annual Meeting

Survey Results

- ▶ Low response rate (24 responses)

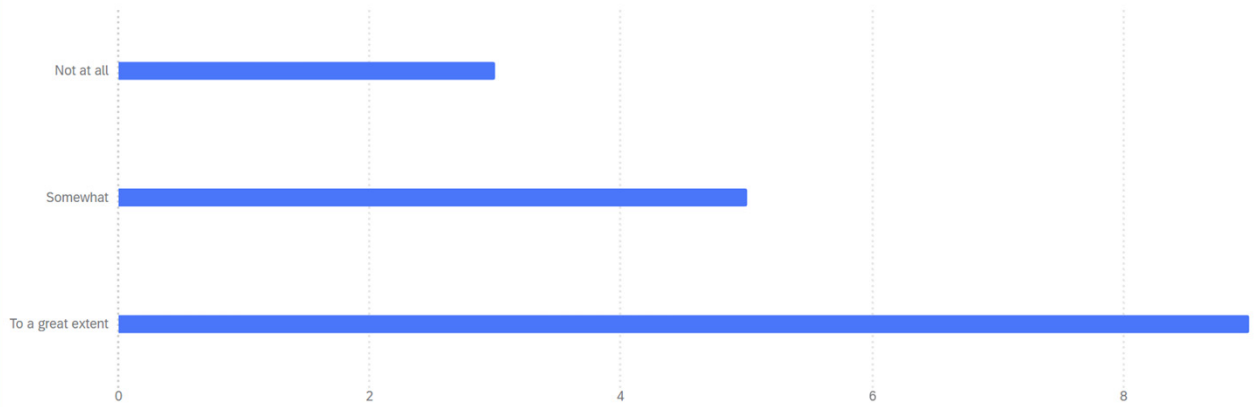
How concerned are you about the current uncertainty surrounding federal research funding? 17 ⓘ



USUCGER Annual Meeting

Survey Results

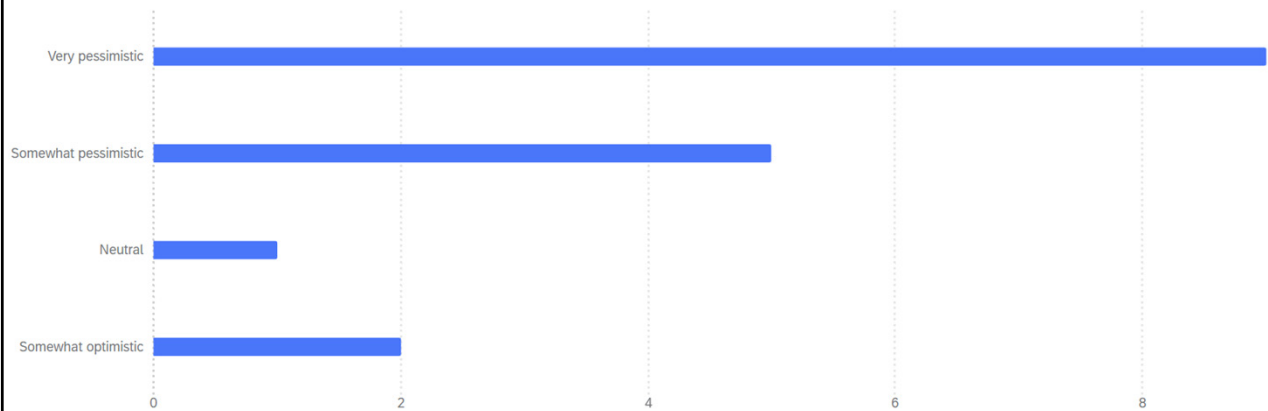
Is the current uncertainty surrounding federal research funding affecting your decisions to hire new or retain existing employees (e.g., graduate s... 17



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Survey Results

Are you feeling generally optimistic or pessimistic about the future of federal funding for geotechnical and/or geoenvironmental research in the n... 17



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Survey Results

- ▶ Examples of impacts:
 - ▶ Major impact seems to be uncertainty
 - ▶ Some current grants and renewals are in limbo
 - ▶ Access to federal resources (collaborators, facilities) is limited
 - ▶ Several respondents indicated that the uncertainty is impacting their ability to make offers to new students

USUCGER Annual Meeting

What should USUCGER be doing?

- ▶ Ideas from survey:
 - ▶ Working with other organizations (e.g., ASCE) on lobbying and statements
 - ▶ Convey impacts to industry and legislators
 - ▶ Share advocacy resources (e.g., template letters)
 - ▶ Start a funding bank to share information on opportunities
- ▶ Developing a strategic plan for USUCGER
- ▶ Other ideas?

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Other business

- ▶ USUCGER members should consider attending the Education Committee (formerly Continuing Education Committee) meeting on Tuesday 3-5pm in Room L008
- ▶ Geotech Education Survey from TC306 (Jorge Zornberg)